Menuschool

Menuschool: Executive Summary

The Problem

Culinary students spend much of their training learning to cook, but far less time learning to run the numbers behind a menu. Food cost, portion yield, and pricing are what decide whether a restaurant survives, yet many programs teach these topics with handouts, spreadsheets, or textbook examples that use outdated or made-up prices. Instructors we spoke with told us they want to teach costing with real data, but building costed lesson plans by hand takes a long time. A single recipe can have fifteen or twenty ingredients, each with different purchase units, trim loss, and yields, and prices change often.

Allergen labeling is a second gap. Students are expected to know the major allergens and how to communicate them on a menu, but instructors usually cover this in a separate lecture instead of building it into every recipe students work with. As a result, costing and allergen awareness are taught as isolated topics instead of as part of one menu planning process.

The result is that graduates often enter kitchens without practical experience in menu costing. Several chefs we interviewed said this is one of the first things they have to teach new hires.

Our Solution

Menuschool is a software platform and consulting service that converts instructors' recipes into costed, allergen-labeled digital lesson plans. An instructor enters or uploads a recipe. The software matches each ingredient to a pricing database, applies purchase unit conversions and yield factors, calculates cost per portion and food-cost percentage, and flags the major allergens. The instructor can then turn the recipe into an assignment, for example asking students to reduce the food-cost percentage below a target without removing an allergen warning, or to build a three-course menu within a budget.

Students see the same data the instructor sees and can change ingredients, portions, and menu prices to watch the numbers move. The goal is for menu planning to feel like a real decision with trade-offs, not a worksheet.

The consulting side supports programs that have large recipe collections and little time. We convert existing recipes into the platform, set up pricing sources, and help instructors map lesson plans to their course outcomes.

Market

Our initial customers are culinary programs in the United States, including community college programs, private culinary schools, and some high school career and technical programs. Based on our own count from public program listings, there are roughly several hundred such programs nationally, though we have not yet verified this figure against an authoritative source. We estimate each program has between three and ten instructors who teach some form of menu planning or cost control.

If we assume an average program pays a few thousand dollars per year, the addressable market in the United States is in the low single-digit millions of dollars annually. This is a small market on its own, which is why we see it as a starting point. Later opportunities include hospitality management programs, corporate training for restaurant groups, and continuing education for working cooks.

Business Model

We plan three sources of revenue. First, annual program licenses priced per instructor seat, which we expect to be our main recurring revenue. Second, one-time conversion and onboarding services, where we digitize a program's recipe library for a fixed fee. Third, optional

curriculum alignment consulting, billed per project.

Our early pricing assumption is a license in the range of several hundred dollars per instructor per year, with conversion packages priced by the number of recipes. These numbers come from conversations with a small number of instructors and are not yet tested with real purchase decisions. We expect programs to buy through department budgets or career and technical education funds, which can mean slow sales cycles.

Competition

Instructors currently use general recipe costing tools designed for restaurants, spreadsheets they build themselves, or the costing exercises that come with textbooks. Restaurant costing software is powerful but is built for operators, not for teaching, and it does not generate lesson plans or student assignments. Spreadsheets are flexible and free but time-consuming, and they do not handle allergens or pricing updates well. Textbook exercises are easy to adopt but use fixed prices that quickly become stale.

Our advantage is that we are built specifically for teaching: recipes become assignments, students see live cost data, and allergens are part of the same workflow. A weakness is that larger software companies could add an education mode to existing products, and we have not yet shown that instructors will pay for something they can partly do with spreadsheets. Our pricing data also depends on third-party sources, which we are still evaluating for cost and reliability.

Team

Danielle Okafor-Reyes is a culinary arts graduate student at our university and a former line cook and kitchen supervisor. She leads curriculum design and instructor relationships. Marcus Tillbrook is a computer science senior who built the prototype and leads product development. Priya Venkataraman studies business and handles customer interviews, pricing, and financial planning. We have not yet added an advisor from the foodservice industry, though we are speaking with two possible candidates. None of us has run a company before.

Milestones and Financials

We have defined the core concept and built a working prototype that handles recipe entry, ingredient costing with unit conversion, food-cost percentage, and allergen flagging. We have a basic website describing the service. Instructors at two programs, one community college and one private school, have used the prototype with a total of roughly forty students in trial assignments. Feedback so far has been positive about time savings, and instructors asked for better handling of regional ingredient pricing and support for batch recipes. We have not yet collected payment from any customer, and we have not formed a legal entity.

Our costs so far are small and have been covered personally by the team: hosting, a few software subscriptions, and travel to visit one program. Over the next twelve months we project spending mostly on pricing data access, part-time development help, and basic legal and accounting setup. Our rough target is five paying programs by the end of the first year, which would bring in revenue in the tens of thousands of dollars, not enough to cover full salaries but enough to show demand. These projections are early estimates and will change as we learn more.

What We Are Asking For

We are seeking prize funding to cover legal formation of the company, a one-year pricing data subscription, and paid pilots at three to five additional programs. We would also value mentorship from people with experience selling software to schools or colleges, introductions to culinary program directors, and advice on how to structure pricing and contracts for public institutions. Finally, we would welcome feedback on whether our market is large enough to support a standalone company or whether we should position Menuschool as a feature within a broader hospitality education offering.